

A PRABHAKAR RAO



APOLOGETIC: Chiranjeevi (left) with Rajasekhara

stunned Chiranjeevi immediately launched a damage control exercise. He called on Rajasekhara at his home and offered a personal apology. "My fans have taken his comments to heart and reacted violently. I condemn their act. I do not want their admiration to lead to violent reactions," a visibly upset star said.

But Rajasekhara is not about to put the issue to rest. "This is inhuman. Though he has apologised, he says his fans resorted to violence without his knowledge. It would be better for us to seek protection from his fans," declared the distraught actor who appealed to Chief Minister Y.S.

Rajasekhara Reddy for security cover. His demand has been accepted and the state has provided two gunmen for his round-the-clock security.

If nothing else, the shameful incident sure had all the trappings of a Telugu blockbuster.

by Amarnath K. Menon

The Hanging Bridge

DELHI The Supreme Court has asked AIADMK chief J. Jayalalithaa to approach the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) to get the Ram Sethu—a 48-km long chain of limestone shoals—be declared a national monument. Responding to a petition filed by her, the apex court said the matter was beyond its purview.

This brings to close another round in the battle over the canal which

HK RAJASEKHARA



FIGHTING ON: Jayalalithaa

has pitted VHP and BJP—which believes it was built by Lord Ram—against DMK, which had flagged off the Rs 2,400 crore project in 2005.

Jayalalithaa had flayed Transport Minister T.R. Baalu for writing to Defence Minister A.K. Antony over navy chief Admiral Sureesh Mehta's doubting the canal's viability. Mehta had said that only ships with a draught of 12 metres could pass through. Larger ships, which the 90-km long channel is meant to wean away from the long route around Sri Lanka, need at least 17 metres. Last year, UPA had distanced itself from an ASI statement which held that there was no evidence to support that the bridge was built by Lord Ram. It remains to be seen how ASI reacts to the ball coming back into its court. by Sandeep Unnithan

Fanning a Starry Fued

HYDERABAD Adulation by overzealous fans can also prove costly at times. Telugu star Chiranjeevi learnt it the hard way when his irate fans attacked actor Rajasekhara, his wife Jeevitha and their 10-year-old daughter. Rajasekhara's "fault" was that he had dared to voice his opinion against Chiranjeevi and said, "I will not join a political party floated by Chiranjeevi. I don't think he has the experience."

The fans, demanding a public apology from Rajasekhara tried to storm into the coach in which the trio was travelling. When the shocked family got off at Hyderabad, some men tailed their car and later attacked them with sticks and stones. As if to prove their dedication to their hero, Chiranjeevi's fans even filmed the attack and sent it to television channels.

Not amused by such show of affection, a

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